

Different Effects of Shame and Guilt on Grief among Bereaved College Students in China



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Introduction

Bereavement, i.e., the loss of significant others, generally arouses grief reactions (e.g., longing for or persistent preoccupation with the deceased) accompanied by potential feelings of guilt and shame.

Since bereavement could be a disruption of one's pre-loss meaning structures, **grief adaptation could be regarded as a process of meaning-making (MM)**. Existing literature showed that **guilt and shame may have different effects on this process**.

Study aims: Examine the differential roles of guilt and shame in grief and their mechanisms related to MM among bereaved college students.

Methods

Prolonged Grief Questionnaire-Revised. 10 items; higher score indicates more grief symptoms.

Grief Experience Questionnaire. 5 items for each subscale; higher score indicates higher level of guilt / shame.

Integration of Stressful Life Experiences Scale. 16 items; higher score indicates stronger MM.

Procedures. The participants were recruited through online questionnaire, followed up once every 3 months for 3 times in total. College students within 5 years of bereavement, not in the midst of a psychotic episode were included in the final sample.

Data analyses. Cross-lagged panel modeling was conducted to examine the temporal relationships between grief, guilt, and shame in Mplus 8.7., controlling for sex & age of participant, age of deceased, intimacy with deceased, and time since loss.

Results & Discussion

Table 1 Characteristics of the final sample (N = 396)

Demographic information	M (SD)	Loss-related information	M (SD)
Age of participant	21.77(1.97)	Time since loss (months)	12.93(10.58)
Age of deceased	67.57(19.51)	Intimacy with deceased	4.36(0.77)
Sex of participant	n (%)		
Male	165(41.7)	Female	231(58.3)

Most bereaved students had lost their grandparent (71.2%).
Causes of the death are mostly disease (60.3%) or old age (21.0%).

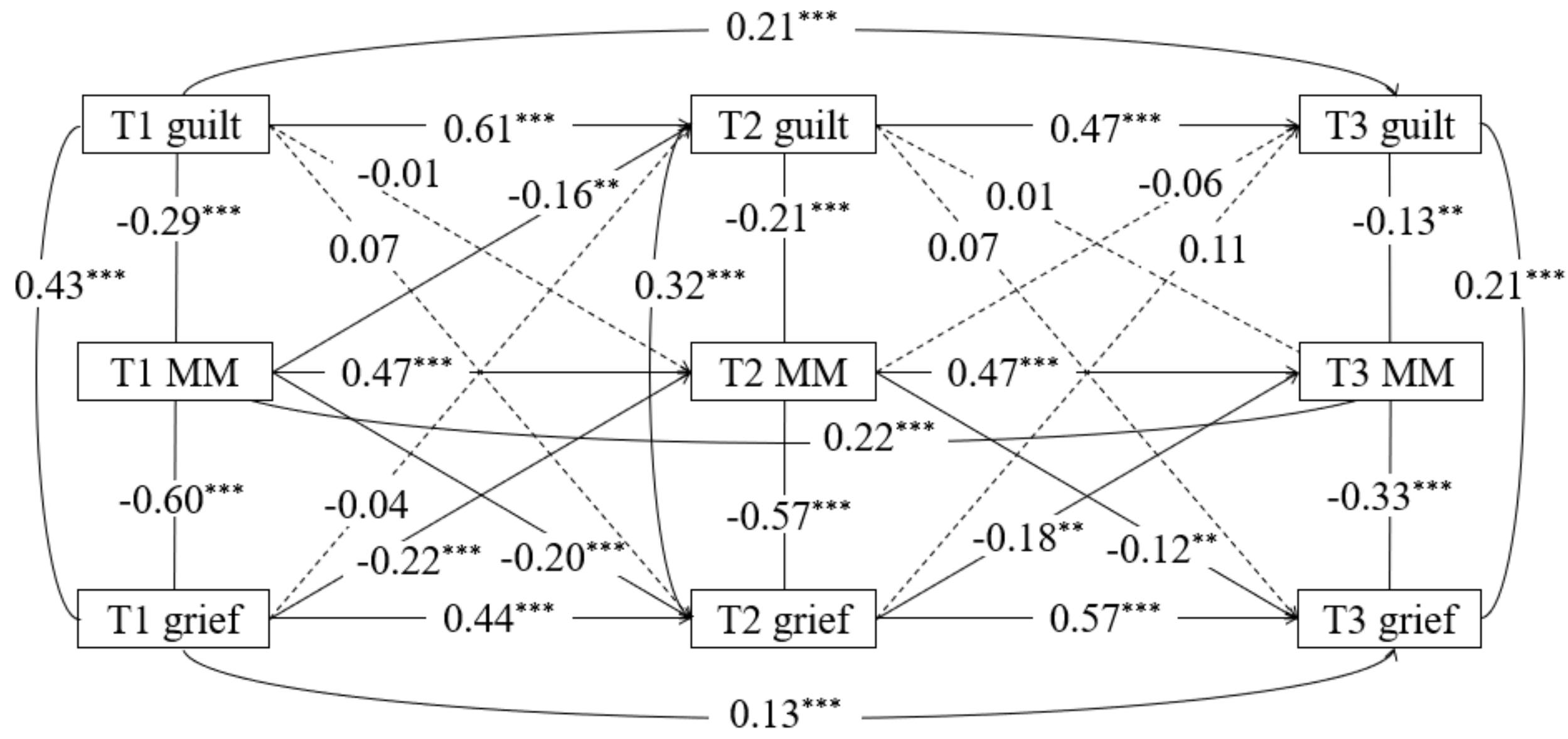


Fig. 1 Longitudinal relationships among levels of **guilt**, MM and grief

Note (Same as below): * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$; Dashed line indicated that the path coefficient is not significant; Standardized coefficients were displayed, covariates were not for simplicity.

T1-guilt showed a non-significant link with T2-MM and T2-grief, while MM and grief showed reciprocal negative effects on each other at all time points. Bootstrap tests showed **non-significant mediation effects** through T1-guilt, T2-MM, and T3-grief (95% CI [-0.010, 0.012]).

Although contrary to common sense, these findings are consistent with a small body of existing literature, which suggests non-significant association between guilt and grief intensity.

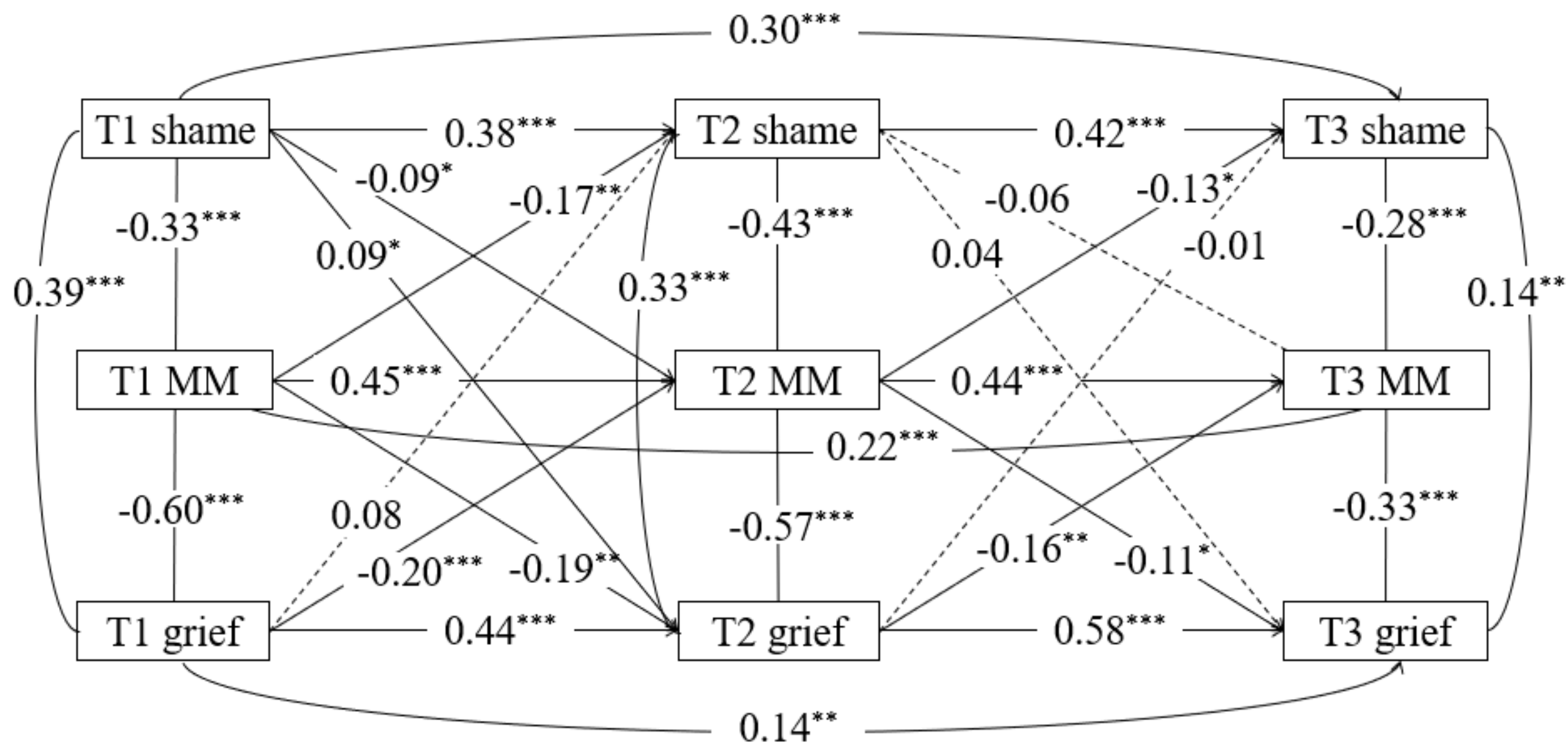


Fig. 2 Longitudinal relationships among levels of **shame**, MM and grief

T1-shame was found negatively related to T2-MM, while the latter was negatively related to T3-grief, and importantly, **the reverse relations were also significant**. However, the Bootstrap test implied that the **indirect effect from T1-shame to T3-grief was non-significant** (95% CI [-0.004, 0.023]).

Although both mediation analyses were not significant, the path coefficient and its significance indicate that higher level of shame has a more prominent predictive effect on worse MM and on higher grief intensity.

Notably, results showed potential reciprocal relationships between shame, MM, and grief. Since the characteristic of grief is dwelling on the deceased, more intense grief could result in more difficulties in accepting the death of the deceased, and thus to arouse more feelings of shame.

Conclusion

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The above results imply **stronger and more stable bidirectional effects between shame and grief intensity**, which aligns with the different connotations of guilt and shame related to self-concept. Additionally, it's important to become aware of **the vicious cycle between shame and grief**, which suggests the necessity to help reduce bereaved students' shame and better adapt to their grief in clinical practice. Whether there are boundary conditions in the role of guilt in grief adaptation needs to be addressed in the future.

Main references

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